A Study of Reading Order in Two Column Pages

Reading order is easy when a page has one column, because the text simply runs from the top of the page to the bottom. Two columns change that, since the eye jumps to the top of the second column after finishing the first one.

A screen reader must make the same jump. Without help, it reads straight across the page and mixes the two columns together.

The heuristic used here cuts the page into regions wherever it finds a clear empty band. A title that spans both columns is read first, then the left column, then the right. Paragraphs are separated by extra vertical space between two lines.

Narrow gaps inside a line, such as the space between two words, never cause a cut. Only gutters of a full em or more count.